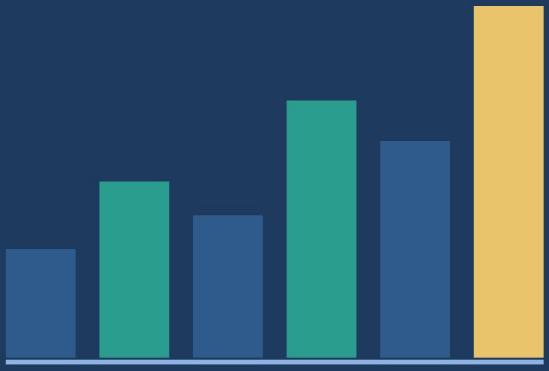
THE ANALYST'S CAREER GUIDE

FROM SPREADSHEET TO SHORTLIST

The Analyst's Guide to a CV, a Portfolio and the Skills That Get You Hired



EMMANUEL OMOWUMI

Excel | SQL | Power BI | Python

From Spreadsheet to Shortlist

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FREE SAMPLE: INTRODUCTION AND CHAPTER 1

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Free sample. This sample contains the Introduction and Chapter 1 of the full book. You may share it freely, in full and unchanged.

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Introduction: Why This Book Exists

Every year, thousands of people learn Excel, Power BI and Python and then wait for a job offer that does not come. They have certificates. They have completed courses. What they often do not have is **proof**: a CV that survives the first automated scan, a portfolio a hiring manager can open in two minutes, and the confidence to explain their work out loud.

This book is about closing that gap.

It is written for people who want to become **business analysts, financial analysts, operations analysts or data analysts**, whether you are a fresh graduate, a career changer from another field, or a junior analyst who wants a stronger case for the next role. It assumes you are willing to practise. It does not assume you have a technical degree.

What makes this book different

Most books on this subject do one of three things. They teach a tool, they give general career advice, or they show polished examples that nobody can reproduce. This book does something more practical. It follows the path a hiring manager actually sees:

1. **The CV** that must pass an automated scan and then convince a human in thirty seconds.
2. **The portfolio** that proves you can do the work, with real projects, clear write-ups and honest limitations.
3. **The skills** behind that proof: Excel, SQL, Power BI and Python, taught as tools for answering business questions, not as a list of features.
4. **The interview** where you explain your thinking.

A note from the author

I did not start in data. My first degree and my master's degree are in microbiology, and I spent time as a quality analyst working with laboratory and production test data, where a wrong number could mean a contaminated product. That job taught me habits I still use every day: check the data before you trust it, find the root cause rather than the symptom, look at trends rather than single points, and write things down so someone else can act on them.

I then moved into business intelligence and analytics, working with dashboards, SQL reporting and sales data. Along the way I built a portfolio of projects, some on real public data and some on synthetic data that I generated, and I learned what makes a portfolio work and what makes it fail. Everything in this book comes from that experience and from the projects described in Part 4.

How to use this book

- **If you are starting from zero,** read Part 1, then work through Part 2 one tool at a time while you begin your first portfolio project from Part 4.
- **If you already know the tools,** go straight to Part 4 (portfolio) and Part 5 (CV), then Part 6 (getting hired).
- **If you have an interview next week,** read Chapter 18 and Appendix G first.

Each chapter ends with a short **Try it** section. Do the exercises. A book can describe the work, but only practice builds the skill.

What this book will not do

It will not promise you a job. Hiring depends on the market, your location, your experience and a good deal of luck. What it will do is help you remove the avoidable reasons for being rejected: a CV that cannot be read, a portfolio that does not show your thinking, and answers you have never practised.

> ***Note on data and examples.*** *Several projects in this book use synthetic data, meaning data I generated myself so that the analysis has something real to find. I say so every time, and you should do the same in your own portfolio. Projects based on real public data are labelled as such.*

About the Author

Emmanuel Omowumi is a data analyst based in Ibadan, Nigeria. He holds an M.Sc. and a B.Sc. in Microbiology from Kwara State University and a B.Sc. in Plant Biology from the University of Ilorin. He has worked as a Data Analyst in sales analytics, as a Senior Data Analyst building Power BI and Tableau dashboards and SQL reports, and as a Quality In-Process Analyst analysing microbiological and production test data.

He builds end-to-end analytics projects in Power BI, SQL and Python on Nigerian, healthcare and e-commerce data, and publishes the code and write-ups on GitHub at **github.com/Nuelwumi2024**. His portfolio is at **nuelwumi2024.github.io**.

Part 1: The Job and the Roadmap

Chapter 1: What Analysts Actually Do

An analyst turns data into a decision. That is the whole job. Everything else, the tools, the dashboards, the code, is a way of doing it faster, more reliably, or for more people.

The four kinds of analyst

Job titles are messy, and the same person may do all four jobs below in a small company. It still helps to know the differences, because each type asks different questions and values different skills.

Type	The question they answer	Typical data	Typical output
Business analyst	What does the business need, and is it working?	Sales, customers, process, requirements	KPI reports, requirements, recommendations
Financial analyst	Are we making money, and will we?	Budgets, accounts, costs, forecasts	Variance reports, models, margin analysis
Operations analyst	Is the process fast, cheap and reliable?	Orders, delivery, inventory, quality	Process metrics, bottleneck analysis
Data analyst	What does the data say, and can we trust it?	Any of the above, in databases and files	Clean datasets, dashboards, analysis

In this book I use "analyst" for all four, and I point out where they differ.

A day in the life

Here is an ordinary week for a junior analyst at a retailer:

- **Monday:** refresh the weekly sales dashboard, check that the numbers match finance, and fix a broken data connection.
- **Tuesday:** a manager asks why returns rose last month. You pull the data, find that one product category and one courier

explain most of it, and write three lines in an email.

- **Wednesday:** clean a messy export from a supplier and add it to the model.
- **Thursday:** build a small analysis for next month's promotion: which customers to target.
- **Friday:** present findings in a ten-minute meeting.

Notice what is *not* in that week: advanced mathematics, machine learning, or any single heroic piece of code. Most analyst work is **asking a good question, getting clean data, doing a straightforward calculation, and explaining the answer clearly**.

The five skills that matter most

1. **Asking the right question.** A vague request like "look at sales" becomes a useful one like "which products lost margin in the last two quarters, and why?"
2. **Data handling.** Finding, cleaning and combining data without breaking it.
3. **Calculation and logic.** Averages, ratios, growth rates, joins and filters. Mostly arithmetic, applied carefully.
4. **Communication.** Charts, written summaries and spoken explanations that a non-technical person can act on.
5. **Judgement.** Knowing when a number looks wrong, and when to say "the data cannot answer that."

Tools matter, but they come after these. A person with strong judgement and Excel will usually beat a person with Python and no judgement.

Where analysts work

Almost every sector hires analysts: banking and fintech, retail and e-commerce, telecoms, healthcare, logistics, manufacturing, government and consulting. If your first degree is in another field, that is an advantage, not a handicap. A scientist

understands experiments. An accountant understands the numbers. A teacher understands how to explain. Part of your job in the next chapters is to learn to say so.

> ***Try it.*** *Open three job adverts for "analyst" roles in a sector you like. For each, highlight the* ***questions the analyst will answer*** *and the* ***tools they ask for****. You will use this list in Chapter 2.*

What is in the full book

You have read the Introduction and Chapter 1. The full book goes on to cover:

- **Part 2: The Toolkit.** Excel, PivotTables and dashboards; SQL; Power BI and DAX; Python and pandas, with shortcut and formula cheat sheets.
- **Part 3: Thinking Like an Analyst.** Business, financial and operational analysis, and turning numbers into a story.
- **Part 4: Build the Portfolio.** How to choose projects, six worked project blueprints with real results, and how to publish on GitHub, a website and LinkedIn.
- **Part 5: The CV That Gets Read.** How CV-scanning software works, bullets that show results, a full sample CV, a cover letter and LinkedIn templates.
- **Part 6: Getting Hired.** Finding local, international and remote roles; interview questions with model answers; your first 90 days.
- **Appendices.** Excel shortcuts, DAX, SQL and pandas references, resources and data sources, checklists and a 12-week study plan.

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LinkedIn: linkedin.com/in/emmanuel-omowumi-98bb03139

Portfolio: nuelwumi2024.github.io

GitHub: github.com/Nuelwumi2024